

DEFINING INTELLECTUAL AND DEVELOPMENTAL DISABILITY: A COMPARATIVE OVERVIEW ACROSS FIVE NATIONAL DATASETS

By Ryan Wedeking & Daria Domin

Introduction

Since 1988, Access to Integrated Employment (AIE) based at the Institute for Community Inclusion (ICI) has described trends in day and employment services and outcomes for individuals with intellectual and developmental disabilities (IDD). This research project explores the factors that contribute to employment outcomes at multiple levels: individual achievement, employment support practices, service provider engagement, and state policy reform.

AIE implements ICI's National Survey of State IDD Agency Employment and Day Services (IDD Survey) and analyzes secondary data from four main sources. In this Data Note, we share a comparative overview of the different definitions of IDD from each of the following five sources, and a brief discussion about these differences.

1. National Survey of State IDD Agency Employment and Day Services (ICI)
2. Rehabilitation Services Administration (RSA)
3. American Community Survey (ACS)
4. National Core Indicators® - Intellectual and Developmental Disabilities (NCI®-IDD)
5. Social Security Administration (SSA)

Even though these sources include data on employment and day services and outcomes for people with IDD, we cannot directly compare their data. This is because each dataset defines the IDD population differently.

The goals of this Data Note are to:

- » provide clarity about how each data source defines the IDD population
- » support readers' understanding of the results from each source

DATA SOURCES



How Intellectual Disability and Developmental Disability Are Defined

The broadly accepted definitions of intellectual disability and developmental disability were developed by the American Association on Intellectual and Developmental Disabilities (AAIDD). Under this definition, **intellectual disability** is:

“a condition characterized by significant limitations in both intellectual functioning and adaptive behavior that originates before the age of 22; an intellectual disability is considered a type of developmental disability (AAIDD, n.d.).

What is **intellectual functioning**? “Intellectual functioning refers to general mental capacity, such as learning, reasoning, problem solving, and so on (AAIDD, n.d.).

What is **adaptive behavior**? “Adaptive behavior is the collection of conceptual, social, and practical skills that are learned and performed by people in their everyday lives” (AAIDD, n.d.).

Note that the term **“developmental disability”** includes intellectual disabilities as well, meaning it is possible for an individual to have a developmental disability and not an intellectual disability; but an individual with an intellectual disability is always considered to have a developmental disability (Institute on Community Integration, 2023; AAIDD, n.d.).

How AIE Collects Data on IDD

Despite this detailed and clear definition, each of the five national level datasets that AIE works with define IDD and include individuals with IDD in their surveys in distinct ways. This makes it challenging to compare data across sources.

Some datasets include people who receive a service or benefit, such as ICI’s IDD Survey and the NCI®-IDD. The population with IDD is implied due to who we collect the data from and where this population is receiving services.

The RSA-911 dataset defines IDD in terms of the ability to participate in employment. The SSA dataset uses the term intellectual disorder and captures information about eligible individuals receiving SSI benefits. In this case, IDD is collected as part of the eligibility process.

The ACS captures information about individuals who have IDD in the process of surveying the general population. The ACS collects characteristics, including cognitive functioning. However, the ACS has several definitions for who can be defined as “a person with a disability” and does not specify a definition for IDD. Thus, we often group individuals with IDD with those deemed to have a cognitive disability as defined by the ACS. The ACS defines “cognitive disability” as *“Because of a physical, mental, or emotional condition, an individual has serious difficulty concentrating, remembering, or making decisions.”* Please refer to Table 1 for more detailed information.

Table 1. Description of Datasets

Source	Dataset Description	Who is Included in the Dataset
Rehabilitation Services Administration (RSA-911)	The RSA-911 is a federal dataset that captures characteristics, services provided, and education and employment outcomes of individuals receiving vocational rehabilitation (VR) and supported employment services at the point of closure from VR services.	The RSA-911 identifies the primary and secondary source of a person's disability using a list of response codes. ICI opts to report on individuals if intellectual disability (Code 25 in Appendix 4) is reported as the primary or the secondary source of the disability that causes or results in a substantial impediment to employment (Attachment II, data elements 43 and 44) (Department of Education, 2019).
National Survey of State Intellectual and Developmental Disabilities Agencies' Employment and Day Services (IDD Survey)	The ICI administers this survey annually. This survey is a part of a longitudinal study commissioned by the Administration on Intellectual and Developmental Disabilities to analyze day and employment service trends between FY 1988 and the present for individuals with intellectual disabilities and closely related conditions (Winsor et al., 2022).	There is no definition of IDD embedded in the IDD survey. Individuals are included based on the eligibility criteria for service participation established by each state. Individuals reported in the survey receive employment and day services funded or monitored by the state IDD agency. These state IDD agencies provide aggregate data on all individuals in this group.
National Core Indicators® - Intellectual and Developmental Disabilities	The NCI (National Core Indicators) program tracks the outcomes of people with intellectual and developmental disabilities who received services from participating state intellectual and developmental disabilities agencies. The National Association of State Directors of Developmental Disabilities Services and the Human Services Research Institute coordinate the NCI (National Core Indicators, 2019).	There is no definition of IDD embedded in the NCI survey. Individuals are included based on the eligibility criteria for service participation established by each state. Data are collected from a random sample of individuals who received services from IDD state agencies. The data are then aggregated and used to support state efforts to strengthen long-term care policy, inform the conduct of quality assurance activities, and compare state performance with national norms.
Social Security Annual Statistical Survey (SSA)	The SSA reports work-incentive participation and the number of individuals receiving Supplemental Security Income (SSI) who are working. SSI is federal program for older adults who are blind and/or disabled and who meet income and resource requirements. It is most common for adults with an intellectual disability to receive SSI. Individuals are considered to be disabled only if their mental impairment(s) is/are of such severity that they are not only unable to do their previous work but cannot—because of their age, education, or work experience—engage in any other kind of substantial gainful activity ¹ that exists in the national economy, regardless of whether such work exists in the immediate area in which they live, or whether a specific job vacancy exists for them, or whether they would be hired if they applied for work (Social Security Administration, 2021).	Beginning with the 2020 SSI Annual Statistical Report, tables showing data by diagnostic group provide more specific details for mental disorders in these categories: • autism spectrum disorder • developmental disorders • childhood and adolescent disorders not elsewhere classified • intellectual disorders • depressive, bipolar, and related disorders • neurocognitive disorders • schizophrenia spectrum and other psychotic disorders • other mental disorders AIE reports primarily on intellectual disorders within the mental disorders diagnostic group.
American Community Survey (ACS)	The ACS provides a population perspective on employment of individuals that is not linked to participation in funded services. ACS is a nationwide annual survey designed by the US Census Bureau. ACS collects information from all 50 states and DC on topics, such as disability, age, race, income, commute time to work, home value, veteran status, and other important data each year. The ACS surveys a representative sample on an annual basis whereas the US Census occurs every 10 years and aims to capture every resident of the United States (US Census Bureau, 2021).	The ACS does not identify individuals as having an intellectual or developmental disability. Starting in 2008, the question that best captures individuals with IDD is: "Because of a physical, mental, or emotional condition, does this person have serious difficulty concentrating, remembering, or making decisions?" The ACS identifies this group of people as having a cognitive disability. However, it includes more than individuals with IDD. AIE reports on individuals who have a cognitive disability and on individuals with any disability or no disability.

¹ Substantial gainful activity describes a level of work activity that is productive and yields or usually yields remuneration or profit. The Social Security Administration's regulations establish a dollar amount to indicate whether a person's work is substantial.

References

- American Association on Intellectual and Developmental Disabilities (n.d.). Defining Criteria for Intellectual Disability. Retrieved August 25, 2023, from <https://www.aidd.org/intellectual-disability/definition>
- Department of Education (2019) Policy Directive RSA-PD-19-03, May 6, 2019 <https://rsa.ed.gov/sites/default/files/subregulatory/pd-19-03.pdf>
- Institute on Community Integration. What are Intellectual and Developmental Disabilities? Retrieved October 23, 2023, from <https://ici.umn.edu/welcome/definition>
- National Core Indicators (2019). In-person survey, 2017–2018 Final Report. Cambridge, MA: Human Services Research Institute. Retrieved from https://legacy.nationalcoreindicators.org/upload/core-indicators/17-18_IPS_National_Report_PART_I_update_CA_entitlement.pdf
- Social Security Administration. (2021). SSI Annual Statistical Report: 2021. https://www.ssa.gov/policy/docs/statcomps/ssi_asr/
- StateData.info | Statedata.info. (n.d.). Retrieved August 25, 2023, from <https://www.statedata.info/>
- US Census Bureau. (2021). American Community Survey and Puerto Rico Community Survey. 2021 Subject Definitions.
- Winsor, J., Butterworth, J., Migliore, A., Domin, D., Zalewska, A., Shepard, J., & Kamau, E. (2022). StateData: The national report on employment services and outcomes through 2019. Boston, MA: University of Massachusetts Boston, Institute for Community Inclusion.



Funding

This Data Note is a product of ThinkWork! at the Institute for Community Inclusion, University of Massachusetts Boston, funded in part by the Administration on Developmental Disabilities, U.S. Department of Health and Human Services (#90DNPA0002). The opinions contained in this DataNote are those of the grantee and do not necessarily reflect those of the funders.

Suggested Citation

Wedeking, R. and Domin, D. (2023). Defining Intellectual and Developmental Disability: A Comparative Overview Across Five National Datasets. Data Note 86. Boston, MA: University of Massachusetts Boston, Institute for Community Inclusion.